International Teacher Education

Active learning and teaching styles in history lessons

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Main ideas about learning

Active learning is any teaching approach that involves students in the lesson instead of leaving them to listen quietly (Prince, 2004). Learner complete tasks. Think about what they are doing, rather than only memorizing information (Bonwell & Eison 1991). Allen et al. (2005) Add that pupils must carry some responsibility for the activity because ownership and personal involvement drive learning.

Activity is not the same as being busy. A lesson can keep pupils occupied while they stay passive, for example when the teacher directs every step (Allen et al., 2005). Doing alone is not enough either: understanding grows through reflection and discussion, which makes learning experiential (Allen et al., 2005). This echoes Vygotskys view that concepts cannot be drilled into children but must be actively constructed (Vygotsky, 1986 as cited in Allen et al., 2005).

The benefits are well documented. Short regular tasks keep students engaged. Show the teacher who is following (Stewart-Wingfield & Black 2005). Active learning also raises exam scores. Lowers failure rates compared with lectures (Freeman et al., 2014; Hake, 1998) with the clearest gains on specific topics covered in class (Michel et al. 2009). Pupils gain satisfaction, teamwork, and mutual respect while teachers gain time for formative feedback (Allen et al., 2005). Planning takes effort but a course need not be rewritten (Brame, 2016).

Active learning does not replace instruction. Some knowledge, such as dates, must be learned by rote and teachers still need to tell pupils when they are wrong, so the method should match the purpose (Allen et al., 2005). Mosstons spectrum of teaching styles supports this choice because it describes who makes decisions before during and after a lesson (Mosston & Ashworth 2002 as cited in Capel et al., 2005). In the command style, the teacher decides everything, which suits introducing a chronology or safe procedure. The practice style gives pupils freedom within a set task, and the reciprocal style lets pairs judge each other's work against criteria. The inclusion style offers entry levels so that every learner can succeed. In guided discovery, the teacher designs questions that lead pupils to an answer; in divergent discovery several answers are valid, and pupils judge them which suits historical interpretation (Capel et al., 2005).

No style is better than another. Capel et al. (2005) Describe "mobility ability": shifting styles to fit the learning objective. Mosston and Ashworth argue that independent learning only begins once teachers include discovery styles (as cited in Capel et al., 2005). Challenge also depends on questioning. Moving from recall towards analysis, synthesis and evaluation (Bloom, 1956 as cited in Allen et al., 2005) stops activities from becoming work.

Ten challenging learning activities for history

Each activity names the Mosston style it mostly uses the level of thinking it targets (Bloom, 1956 as cited in Allen et al., 2005) and a digital tool.

1. Source Courtroom

Put a decision on trial for example: Was appeasement a justified policy? Groups act as prosecution, defense, and jury. May only argue with evidence from a pack of primary sources. The jury must justify its verdict in writing.

Style: divergent discovery

Thinking level: evaluation

Digital tool: Padlet evidence wall (each group pins its sources and claims)

2. Mystery Artefacts

Groups receive five images of objects from one period. They deduce who made them why and what they reveal about that society while the teacher guides them with questions before the reveal.

Style: guided discovery

Thinking level: analysis

Digital tool: Google Arts & Culture for the images Google Slides, for group answers

3. Living Timeline

Pupils receive event cards. Physically line up in chronological order then justify each placement. Afterwards they add arrows for cause and consequence. Because chronology is fixed knowledge, the teacher controls the round (command) before pupils decide how to connect with the events (practice).

Style: command, then practice

Thinking level: knowledge and comprehension

Digital tool: TimelineJS or a Miro board can be used to rebuild the timeline online

4. Diamond Nine Causes

Give nine causes of an event, for example the outbreak of the First World War. Pupils will rank those causes in a diamond shape placing the important at the top. They will first rank alone in pairs then in fours and finally defend their final order. Several rankings can be valid.

Style: divergent discovery

Thinking level: evaluation

Digital tool: Miro or Padlet with draggable cards and Mentimeter for a class vote at the end

5. Historian Showdown

Pupils receive two historians' interpretations of the event. Using a DART, which's a directed activity related to texts, they underline claims, evidence, and tone, then write a short dialogue where the historians respond to each other.

Style: guided discovery

Thinking level: analysis and synthesis

Digital tool: Hypothes.is for annotation of online texts

6. Reciprocal Source Coaching

In pairs, one pupil analyzes a source looking at origin, purpose, content, value and limitations while the partner acts as coach with a criteria checklist and gives feedback. Then the pairs swap roles with a source.

Style: reciprocal

Thinking level: analysis

Digital tool: Google Docs comments for the coach's feedback

7. What If? Counterfactual Chain

Pupils change one decision in the past for example an outcome in a key battle and map the likely short-term and long-term consequences. Peers then challenge each link in the chain asking whether it is plausible and what evidence supports it.

Style: divergent discovery

Thinking level: synthesis

Digital tool: Canva flowchart

8. Story Map

Pupils plot a journey on a map, for example a trade route, a migration, or a campaign. Attach a source, a date, and a short explanation to each stop. The teachers guiding questions help them find patterns, such as why routes followed rivers.

Style: guided discovery

Thinking level: application and analysis

Digital tool: Google My Maps

9. Summit Simulation

Each group represents a country at a peace conference, for example Vienna 1815 with a list of goals. Pupils record an opening statement to negotiate and then reflect a debrief on which compromises were historically realistic and why.

Style: divergent discovery, with a reflective debrief

Thinking level: evaluation

Digital tool: Flip (video statements) and Padlet for the final agreement

10. Quiz Battle: Pupils as Question Writers

Pupils write quiz questions about the unit at three levels, recall explain, evaluate. Choose their own entry level so that every learner can succeed. Groups then exchange quizzes. Play each other's questions.

Style: inclusion

Thinking level: all levels, with a focus on creating questions

Digital tool: Kahoot or Quizizz

Planning checklist for learning

Based on Allen et al. (2005):

- Share the learning outcomes and show what successful work looks like.

- Link the lesson to prior knowledge, for example by using a quick spider diagram.

- Prepare support for pupils and extensions for faster pupils.

- Plan time for reflection and discussion because doing alone does not guarantee understanding.

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